

Tutankhamun

Location: inside the dedicated Tutankhamun Galleries on the third floor of the Grand Egyptian Museum (GEM).

Tutankhamun (born Tutankhaten) was the antepenultimate pharaoh of the Eighteenth Dynasty of ancient Egypt, ruling from approximately 1332 BC to 1323 BC. Born around 1342 BC during the Amarna Period under Akhenaten, his original name meant "living image of Aten," reflecting the religious shift to Atenism.

Parentage, Family, and Lineage

- **Father:** Identified through DNA as the male mummy from tomb KV55, generally believed to be Akhenaten or his co-ruler Smenkhkare.
- **Mother:** Identified via DNA as "The Younger Lady" (from tomb KV35), a full sister to the KV55 male and a daughter of Amenhotep III and Queen Tiye. Proposed identities include Nebetah or Becketaten. Alternative non-genetic theories suggest Kiya, Meritaten, Meketaten, or Nefertiti.
- **Wet Nurse:** A woman named Maia.
- **Wife:** Married Ankhesenpaaten (daughter of Akhenaten), who later changed her name to Ankhesenamun.
- **Children:** Fathered two daughters who died at or shortly after birth (one born prematurely at 5–6 months, the other full-term at 9 months). Both were buried alongside him.
- **Dynastic Impact:** His death marked the end of the royal bloodline of the Eighteenth Dynasty.

Accession and Reign

- **Accession:** Acceded to the throne at 8 or 9 years of age, taking the throne name Nebkheperure, following the short reigns of Smenkhkare and Neferneferuaten.
- **Regnal Duration:** Reigned for approximately nine years.
- **Administrative Setup:** The position of Vizier was split between Upper and Lower Egypt (Usermontu served in Upper Egypt, and Pentju held a vizierate role). Ay served as a high-ranking official and Priest of Maat, potentially holding an informal vizier title.
- **Religiopolitical Countermand:**
 - **Relocation:** Abandoned the capital city of Amarna and moved the main seat of royal administration to Memphis, while restoring Thebes as the primary center of religious life.
 - **Restoration of Amun:** Ended Atenism, lifted the ban on the cult of Amun, and restored traditional privileges to the priesthood.
 - **Name Changes:** Changed his name from Tutankhaten to Tutankhamun, and his queen's name from Ankhesenpaaten to Ankhesenamun.
 - **Restoration Stela:** Erected in his 4th regnal year to record his restorations and endowments of ancient cults and monuments.

Architectural and Military Projects

- **Building Projects:**
 - Commissioned the sphinx avenue leading to the Temple of Mut at Karnak (re-heading existing sphinxes with ram heads).
 - Completed the entrance colonnade decoration of Amenhotep III at Luxor Temple.
 - Began constructing a royal tomb and a mortuary temple in Thebes (the Temple-of-Nebkheperure-Beloved-of-Amun-Who-Puts-Thebes-in-Order), which used recycled talatat blocks from Akhenaten's Aten temples.
- **Foreign Policy and Warfare:**
 - Reestablished diplomatic relations with foreign powers, notably the Mitanni.
 - Recorded victories against Nubians and Asiatics in his mortuary temple.
 - Equipped with extensive military gear (over 400 arrows, 40 bows, khopesh swords, armor, and custom weaponry), indicating active military training and probable active participation in warfare.

Death, Burial, and Rediscovery

- **Death:** Died unexpectedly around age 18 in c. 1323 BC. Medical analysis in 2012 indicated a combination of malaria and a leg fracture as the cause of death.
- **Burial:** Due to his sudden death and unfinished royal tomb, he was buried in a small, adapted non-royal tomb in the Valley of the Kings. He was succeeded by his vizier Ay, who was later succeeded by military commander Horemheb.
- **Tomb Discovery:** Discovered in 1922 by Howard Carter and Lord Carnarvon. The tomb contained over 5,000 artifacts, including his intact mummy and burial mask.
- **Artifact Relocation:** His treasures were exhibited globally in various tours (beginning in 1961) and preserved at the Egyptian Museum before being relocated to the Grand Egyptian Museum in 2025.

During-Life Deification of Tutankhamun

- **Lifetime Worship:** Unlike most pharaohs who were only venerated after death through mortuary cults, Tutankhamun was one of the few Egyptian kings worshiped as a living deity during his lifetime.
- **Cult Design:** He patterned his living cult after Amenhotep III (focusing on Amun rather than Aten), creating a structure that Ramesses II would later expand on a much larger scale.

Nubian Temples

- **Temple at Kawa:** Built in Nubia and dedicated to Amun in a local form that was directly identified with Tutankhamun himself.
- **Temple at Faras:**
 - Located in a town called "He who appeases the gods."
 - Named "Pacifying the gods," which matched Tutankhamun's Golden Horus name.

- Dedicated to traditional Egyptian deities (Amun, Amun-Ra, Re-Horakhty) alongside the deified form of Tutankhamun as a local incarnation of Amun.
 - Served a dual theological purpose and acted as the administrative headquarters for Egypt's Nubian government.
- **Symbolism:** Artwork at Kawa (such as criosphinx imagery) depicted Tutankhamun worshiping himself as an incarnation of Amun-Re.

Theban Region & The Stela of Huy

- **Stela Discovery:** Found at Karnak Temple, proving that Tutankhamun's living cult was also active in the Theban region.
- **Hymn Inscriptions:** Contains a hymn that equates the royal spirit (ka) of Tutankhamun with the divine status of the god Amun.
- **Artwork:** Depicts the official Huy offering praise to three deities simultaneously: Amun-Re, a ram-headed Amun, and the deified royal spirit of Tutankhamun.

Cult Hierarchy & Administration

- **Structure:** The living cult's priesthood mirrored the traditional hierarchy of the priesthood of Amun.
- **Cult Officiator:** Viceroy Huy was appointed by Tutankhamun to oversee the cult.
- **Known Key Appointments:**
 - **Khay:** Held the title of First Prophet of Nebkheperura (Tutankhamun's throne name), overseeing the cult operations.
 - **Mermose:** Held the title of Second Prophet of Nebkheperura (younger brother of Viceroy Huy).
 - **Taemwadjsy:** Served as Chief of the Harem of the Deified Tutankhamun.
- **Dedicated Cult Harem:** The harem managed by Taemwadjsy was located at Kawa in Nubia and was strictly dedicated to Tutankhamun's living deified form, kept separate from the standard Harem of Amun-Re.

Health and Medical History

Confirmed Conditions

- **Severe Malaria:** Genetic testing confirmed multiple strains of *Plasmodium falciparum* (malaria tropica), indicating he was repeatedly infected. The infections likely contributed to a severe immune response or circulatory shock.
- **Compound Leg Fracture:** CT scans in 2005 revealed a ragged, unhealed fracture in his left leg. Embalming fluid inside the wound confirms it occurred shortly before death, making death from fracture complications (exacerbated by malaria) highly probable.

Debated and Refuted Podiatric Conditions

- **Clubfoot & Walking Sticks:** A left clubfoot diagnosis led to theories that he required walking aids, supported by over 130 sticks found in his tomb.

- **Counter-Evidence:** Microscopic wear analysis (such as the Tutankhamun's Sticks and Staves Project) showed minimal wear on the stick tips, and his sandals showed symmetrical wear on both feet. Egyptologists conclude the sticks were royal regalia and status symbols, not mobility aids.
- **Dismissed Misdiagnoses:** Genetic testing ruled out several previously hypothesized syndromes used to explain his artistic depictions, including gynecomastia, Marfan syndrome, Antley-Bixler syndrome, and sagittal craniosynostosis.
- **Spinal and Other Theories:** Alleged mild scoliosis was determined to be post-mortem handling by embalmers (no spinal rotation). Other unconfirmed or speculated conditions include Köhler disease II, partial cleft palate, and inherited temporal lobe epilepsy.

Physical Appearance and Facial Reconstructions

- **Build and Stature:** Lean, slender frame standing approximately 167 cm (5 ft 6 in) tall—slightly taller than average for his era. Clothing dimensions indicate a narrow waist and rounder hips.
- **Dental Health:** CT scans showed excellent dentition featuring large front incisors and a prominent overbite characteristic of the Thutmosid royal line.
- **Reconstruction Controversies:**
 - **2005 CT Reconstructions:** Three independent teams (Egyptian, French, American) modeled his face. The lighter skin tone chosen sparked public protests and criticism from scholars who argued it reflected Western bias toward lighter skin tones for ancient Egyptians.
 - **2014 Full-Body Virtual Forensic:** A BBC documentary created a 3D model portraying him as frail, with a clubfoot and gynecomastia. The depiction was widely condemned by Egyptologists and disability scholars as scientifically unfounded and sensationalized.
 - **2022–2023 Digital Updates:** Newer 3D bioimaging created updated facial models. Some omitted skin tones entirely to focus strictly on skeletal accuracy, while others produced features similar to the 2005 results.

Ancestral Genotyping and Population Affinities

- **Paternal and Maternal Haplogroups:**
 - **Y-DNA (Paternal):** Shares haplogroup R1b with his father (the KV55 mummy) and grandfather (Amenhotep III). This lineage is linked to ancient migrations back into Africa via North Africa/Western Asia and is found at notable frequencies in modern Chadic-speaking populations.
 - **mtDNA (Maternal):** Shares haplogroup K with his mother (The Younger Lady), grandmother (Tiye), and great-grandmother (Thuya), originating in the Near East.
- **Autosomal STR Analysis:**
 - Multiple population affinity studies analyzing Short Tandem Repeat (STR) data reported significant genetic affinities with Sub-Saharan African populations alongside secondary Eurasian/Asian affinities.
 - Scholars note this combination of lineages highlights the Nile Valley's historical status as a geographical and cultural crossroads.

Death of Tutankhamun

Circumstances and Probable Cause

- **Lack of Direct Records:** No surviving ancient records document the exact circumstances of his death.
- **Consensus/Main Theory (Hawass and Team):** His death likely resulted from a combination of multiple weakening health disorders, a femur fracture (possibly caused by a fall), and a severe malarial infection.

Disproved Theories

- **Fatal Blow to the Head (Murder Hypothesis):**
 - **Origin:** A 1968 X-ray showed two loose bone fragments inside the skull, leading to speculation that he was murdered by a strike to the head.
 - **Refutation:** Subsequent CT scans and X-ray re-examinations showed the fragments were not stuck to the embalming resin, proving they broke loose during modern unwrapping of the mummy. Furthermore, there was no bone thinning or calcified membrane damage that would indicate a head trauma.
- **Chariot Accident / Crushing Chest Injury:**
 - **Origin:** Suggested due to patterns of crushing injuries and the fact that the front section of his chest wall and ribs are missing.
 - **Refutation:** Photographs taken in 1926 at the end of Howard Carter's excavation clearly show the chest wall intact, adorned with a beaded collar featuring falcon-headed terminals.
 - **Explanation:** The missing chest wall and collar were first noticed in 1968 X-rays. The chest wall was likely destroyed by modern tomb robbers stealing the beaded collar (an intricate beaded skullcap seen in 1926 was also missing by 1968).

Funeral of Tutankhamun

Timing and Seasonality

- **Floral Evidence:** Analysis of funerary flowers and plant arrangements on the innermost coffin provides a timeframe for the funeral:
 - **Renate Germer's Estimate:** Deductions place the funeral between late February and mid-March.
 - **Rolf Krauss's Estimate:** Proposes a slightly later date of March to April.

Burial Chamber Artwork

- **North Wall Scenes:**

- **Left:** Tutankhamun, accompanied by his *ka* (soul aspect), embraces Osiris, god of the dead.
- **Center:** Tutankhamun greets the goddess Nut.
- **Right:** Ay performs the "opening of the mouth" ritual on the deceased Osiris-Tutankhamun.

Key Attendees and Historical Figures

- **Ay:**
 - In attendance and depicted performing the "opening of the mouth" ritual.
 - Performing this ritual was the standard responsibility of the successor, confirming Ay's position as pharaoh was already established at the time of the funeral.
- **Nakhtmin:**
 - A general during Tutankhamun's reign whose presence is confirmed by donated *shabti* figures discovered among the funerary goods.
- **Horemheb (Debated Presence):**
 - **Absent Theory:** Some scholars suggest he was away fighting a military campaign against Asiatics, noting the absence of any burial goods donated by him.
 - **Present Theory (Nozomu Kawai):** Identifies the figure closest to the mummy in the funerary procession depiction as Horemheb, implying he held a leading role in the ceremony.
 - **Alternative Interpretation:** Other scholars argue that this unidentified figure represents Tutankhamun's *ka* rather than Horemheb.

Summary:

Here is a complete bullet-point summary of the personal and biographical information about Tutankhamun compiled from our discussion:

Identity & Lineage

- **Original Name:** Tutankhaten ("living image of Aten"), later changed to Tutankhamun ("living image of Amun") to reflect his restoration of traditional Egyptian religion.
- **Throne Name:** Nebkheperure.
- **Birth & Era:** Born c. 1342 BC during the Amarna Period under Pharaoh Akhenaten; belonged to the Thutmosid royal line of the Eighteenth Dynasty.
- **Father:** Identified via DNA as the male mummy from tomb KV55 (generally believed to be Akhenaten or Smenkhkare).
- **Mother:** Identified via DNA as "The Younger Lady" (tomb KV35), a full sister to the KV55 male and daughter of Amenhotep III and Queen Tiye.
- **Wet Nurse:** Maia.
- **Wife:** Married his half-sister Ankhesenpaaten (later renamed Ankhesenamun).

- **Children:** Fathered two daughters who died at or shortly after birth (one stillborn at 5–6 months, the other full-term at 9 months); both were buried alongside him in his tomb.

Physical Appearance & Build

- **Height & Frame:** Measured approximately 167 cm (5 ft 6 in) tall—on the taller side of average for men in his era—with a lean, slender build, narrow waist, and rounder hips.
- **Facial & Dental Features:** Had large front incisors and a distinct overbite, a inherited trait characteristic of the Thutmosid royal family.

Health & Medical Profile

- **Confirmed Medical Conditions:**
 - **Severe Malaria:** Repeatedly infected with *Plasmodium falciparum* (malaria tropica).
 - **Compound Leg Fracture:** Suffered a severe, unhealed fracture in his left leg shortly before death.
- **Mobility & Strength:** CT scans show no signs of abnormal physical frailty. Analysis of minimal wear on the 130+ sticks/canes in his tomb and symmetrical wear on his sandals indicate they were ceremonial royal regalia rather than medical walking aids.
- **Debunked Misdiagnoses:** Genetic testing and CT re-evaluations disproved theories of clubfoot, gynecomastia, Marfan syndrome, scoliosis (spinal curvature resulted from embalmer handling), and Antley–Bixler syndrome.

Reign, Deification, & Life

- **Royal Rule:** Acceded to the throne around age 8 or 9; ruled for approximately 9 years (c. 1332–1323 BC).
- **Major Accomplishments:** Shifted the capital from Amarna back to Memphis/Thebes, ended Atenism, restored the cult of Amun, and re-established foreign diplomatic relations.
- **Military Role:** Equipped with extensive personal weaponry (over 400 arrows, 40 bows, and khopesh swords) and recorded military victories in Nubia and Asia, indicating active military training and involvement.
- **Living Deification:** One of the few pharaohs worshipped as a living god during his lifetime, establishing dedicated living-cult temples and priesthood structures in Nubia and Thebes.

Death & Funeral

- **Age at Death:** Died unexpectedly around age 18 in c. 1323 BC.
- **Cause of Death:** Likely resulted from complications of his severe left leg fracture compounded by his malarial infection.

- **Funeral Timing:** Floral analysis from his coffin indicates his funeral took place between late February and April.
- **Succession:** Succeeded by his vizier Ay, who performed the "opening of the mouth" ritual at his funeral.